



Figure 3: My finished desktop

didn't seem like an easy process. There are some guides on how to compile and integrate it, but I decided to pass that. In many ways it would also have cancelled the main benefit of running Debian anyway—tried and trusted software that you know will work. If the Debian guys say something is stable, you can believe it's stable—a conservative approach, but I admire their commitment to quality.

Lenny also ships with a much older kernel than I would normally use. My machine kept overheating quite badly, and the fan sounded like a small aircraft attempting to take off or perhaps like trying to watch a film on an Xbox :-). There were some issues with my model of nVidia card soon after its release, till modifications were made to heat management in the Linux kernel to compensate. It now works great and the fan does not normally need to work overtime with the newer kernel. Consistently though, with Lenny I found I needed to leave the machine to cool down. This may be my fault for having the evil nVidia card, but it definitely didn't like the older kernel.

Conclusions

- Ease of installation and use: 2/5
- Stability: 5/5
- Community and documentation: 5/5
- Features: 3/5
- Overall: 4/5

I was able to get the system working as I wanted, under Lenny, but it took some time and expertise. I compiled a lot of the newer software from source when I couldn't find packages. I did try adding the Squeeze repos [www.debian.org/volatile] and even some experimental ones, but still found a lot of the packages were significantly behind. That's what you expect with Debian though—you don't use it because you want the latest cutting edge software; you use it because you want stability, speed and the support of some of the best developers in the business.

There's a very useful guide [www.howtoforge.com/the-perfect-desktop-debian-lenny] to setting up the perfect desktop with Lenny and it introduced me to the Debian-multimedia.org repository. I highly recommend it to everyone to easily add extra multimedia programs.

The overheating problems due to the older kernel were a shame. I could of course install another kernel or even compile one from scratch, but for me, that seems to defeat the purpose of using Debian. It would be easier to use Arch or another distro if that's the aim. Back when I tried Etch, it was on a desktop machine and I think the main difference this time around is I'm on a notebook. I said while reviewing Etch that I was amazed at how much of Ubuntu is Debian painted brown, and that's still true. But I also gained a new appreciation for the work the Ubuntu guys do in making their software run effortlessly on laptops. I like that Debian is very true to its Free Software ethos, including things like Swfdec instead of the proprietary Adobe Flash player. However, in practice I found it didn't work very well, and I ended up ripping it out anyway and installing the evil Adobe Flash.

Do I still love Debian? Yes, of course, I do. And there's no doubt about that. However, I have to confess that maybe I've changed. On my laptop I want the latest and greatest software to play around with. I like to get the newest GNOME, for example, and Debian just isn't the right distro for that. It does have many strengths—Apt is still Debian's killer app for me and I've yet to find another package manager that really compares.

The bottom line though, is that on the desktop I find Debian too conservative for my tastes these days—it's a personal thing. On a server or even a desktop with a specific purpose, it excels and I wouldn't replace it with anything else. If I need a Web server, database server or... well, any other kind of server, I'll be reaching for my Debian CD, because I know it will be rock solid. But on my laptop, I guess I'll keep hopping around in search of new software.

If you've used Linux before and you're not afraid to learn a little bit about its finer workings, Debian has a massive amount to offer and I'd encourage everyone to try it at least once in their life. It's not for everyone, but it's still a great testament to what a group of dedicated volunteer developers can achieve on our behalfs, when they come together. Try it out for yourself and let me know what you think. 

Resources

- Debian's home: www.debian.org
- Full installation slide show: www.flickr.com/photos/mrmethv/sets/72157615695122780/show/
- Debian Free Software Guidelines: www.debian.org/social_contract#guidelines
- Useful guide: www.howtoforge.com/the-perfect-desktop-debian-lenny

By: Dan Lynch

Dan is a 28 year old writer, musician [shedmusic.net], broadcaster, producer and convicted geek from Merseyside in the UK. He is mad about all things open source, particularly GNU/Linux, but also BSD, OpenSolaris and various Web/mobile technologies. He does a bit of programming and Web development, but hasn't done any really meaty projects in a while. You can find out more about him at danlynch.org.

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